Inbound Lead Funnel Analysis

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1. Executive Summary

- **Funnel:** 100 inbound leads, 54 replied (54%), 21 qualified (21% of all leads, 38% of replies) and 10 booked a meeting (10% of all leads, 48% of qualified leads).
- **Biggest findings:** (1) Reply to qualify is the weakest stage, and the qualify rate varies from 22% to 54% by rep on randomly assigned leads. (2) The current ICP does not predict outcomes: ICP-match leads replied less (44.7% vs 62.3%) and booked at about the same rate (10.6% vs 9.4%). (3) First emails go out a median of 3 days after submission, and reply rates are highest when the email goes out on Day 0-1 (58-74% vs 33-44% on Days 2-3).
- **Segments to prioritize:** 51-200 employees (20% meeting rate, 5 of the 10 meetings), Bootstrapped (23%) and Series B (16%) companies, and CEOs (33%) and Marketing Managers (23%). Deprioritize ICs, Public companies, and the 11-50 and 1000+ size bands.
- **Quick wins:** send the first email within a day of submission, give reps a written qualification checklist, and stop routing low converting segments to reps.
- **Strategic:** A/B test a revised ICP (CEO or Marketing Manager, 51-200, bootstrapped) against the current one, and test whether Growth Managers and VP Sales, who reply well but rarely qualify, justify a separate offer. All segment figures sit on 100 leads, so they are directional until tested.

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2. Data Overview

2.1 Dataset The dataset contains 100 inbound leads submitted between an unspecified time period, covering all leads who engaged with Clay via form submission, sign-up, or direct inbound inquiry.

2.2 Data Cleaning The following issues were identified and addressed during preprocessing:

- **Job titles** had high variance (e.g. "Sr. AE", "Senior Account Executive", "senior ae") and were standardized and mapped to the existing `Job_level` field
- **Company size** contained nulls (~4% of records) which were left as NaN and excluded from size-based analysis
- **Funding status** had inconsistent formatting and was normalized to a standard set of categories (Seed, Series A, Series B, Series C+, No Funding, Unknown)
- **Date fields** were converted to datetime format; records where `First_email_sent_date` was before `Form_submission_date` were flagged and removed as data entry errors

2.3 Key Fields Used The following key fields were used from the dataset directly and a few others were derived. Key Fields were the following:

- `Job_title` — the raw job title as entered or scraped from the lead's profile (e.g. "Senior Account Executive", "Head of Growth"). Used as the basis for inferring seniority and function
- `Job_level` — inferred seniority level derived from the job title, standardized into categories (IC, Manager, Director, VP, C-Level, Founder). Used to segment leads by decision-making authority
- `Email_replied` — boolean flag indicating whether the contact replied to the first outreach email. Used as the primary measure of top-of-funnel engagement.
- `Qualified_lead` — boolean flag indicating whether the lead was marked as qualified by the sales rep after initial engagement. Represents the second stage of the funnel and reflects ICP fit as assessed by the rep.
- `Meeting_booked` — boolean flag indicating whether the lead successfully booked a meeting with a sales rep. Represents the primary conversion event and bottom of the inbound funnel.
- `Sales_owner` — the rep or team assigned to work the lead. Used to analyze performance differences across individuals and teams.
- `Company_size` — estimated employee headcount of the lead's company, grouped into bands (1-10, 11-50, 51-200, 201-500, 501-1000, 1000+). Used as a proxy for company scale and ICP fit.
- `Funding_status` — indicates whether and when the company last raised external funding (e.g. Seed, Series A, Series B, Series C+, No Funding). Used as a signal for buying intent and growth stage.

2.4 Derived Fields The following fields were created to support the analysis:

- `Days_to_first_email` — number of days between form submission and first outreach email

- `Response_bucket` — categorical grouping of response time (Same Day, 1-2 Days, 3-5 Days, 6-10 Days, 10+ Days, No Email Sent)
- `ICP_match` — boolean flag based on company size (50-500 employees), funding status (Seed through Series B), and job level (Manager and above)

2.5 Summary Statistics

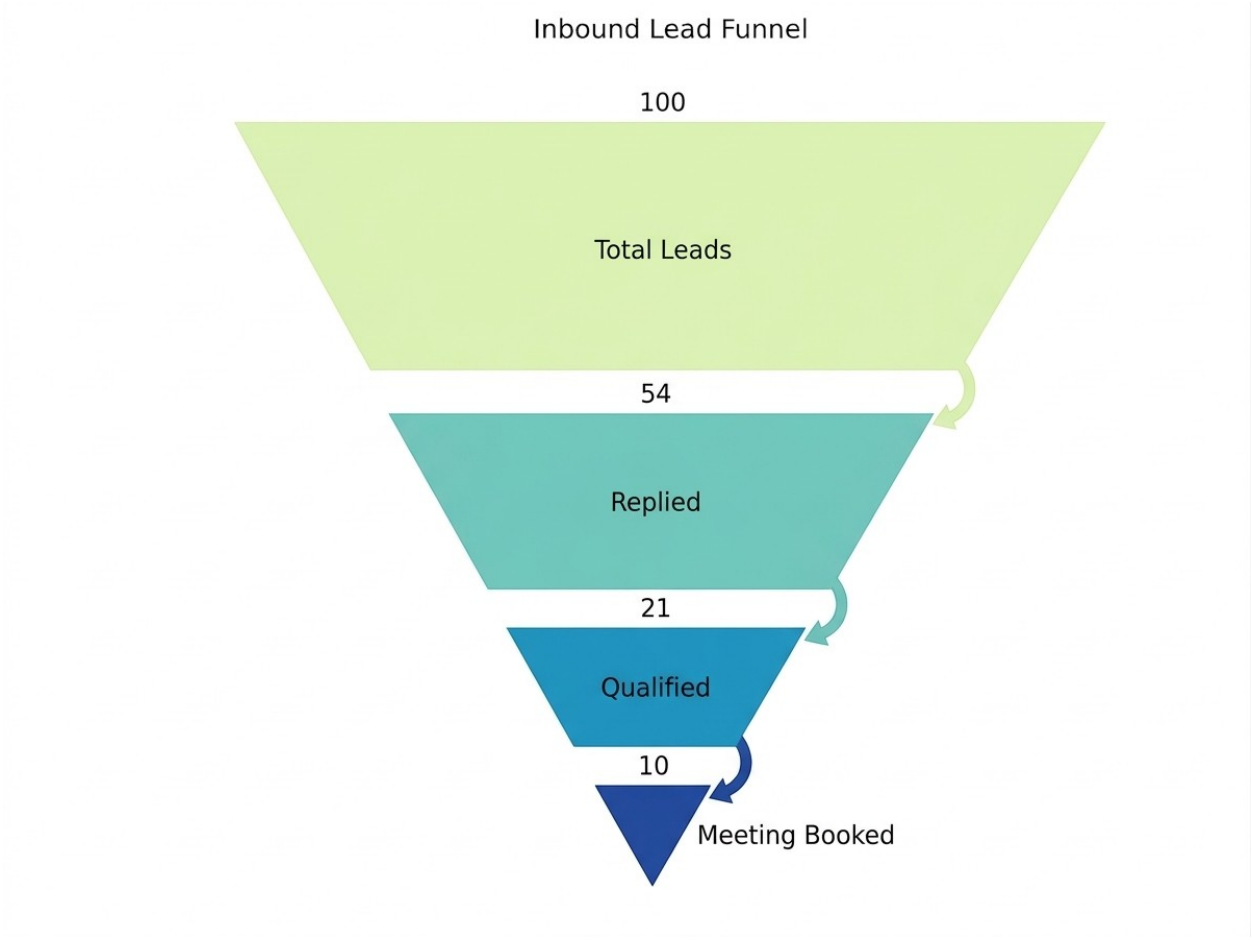
	Sales_team_size	Growth_team_size	days_to_first_email	days_to_reply	Company_size
count	100.00	100.00	100.00	54.00	22,364.00
mean	59.88	25.71	3.19	5.20	254.14
std	51.15	23.42	2.37	3.02	245.31
min	4.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
25%	20.00	9.00	1.00	2.25	30.50
50%	69.00	20.00	3.00	4.50	125.50
75%	90.50	46.25	5.00	7.75	350.50
max	145.00	63.00	7.00	10.00	1,000.00

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3. Funnel Performance

3.1 Overall funnel waterfall

Through the data analysis we are able to plot how the leads move before converting or where we lose them. The metrics used here are the reply rate, qualify rate, and meeting/conversion rate. We can analyze this to make changes to our inbound strategy. Mainly through the next step



3.2 Funnel Drop-off Looking at conversion on a stage-by-stage basis provides a clearer picture of where leads are being lost:

Stage	Denominator	Rate
Reply Rate	Total Leads	54%
Qualify Rate	Replied Leads	38%
Meeting Rate	Qualified Leads	48%

This waterfall view reveals that the **reply-to-qualify conversion is the weakest link** in the funnel — of every 100 leads that reply, only 38 are marked as qualified. This raises the question of whether inbound volume contains a high proportion of low ICP leads that are consuming rep time without converting, or whether the qualification criteria itself needs revisiting.

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4. Segment Analysis

4.1 By Job Level — which seniority converts best, we found that the highest meeting rates came from Founders (16.7%) and VPs (12.5%), while ICs, the largest group at 36% of leads, converted at only 5.6%. Managers made up another 34% of leads and had the lowest reply rate (41%).

Job_level	Leads	%_leads	reply_rate	qualify_rate	conversion_rate
Director	10	10.00	60.00	30.00	10.00
Founder	12	12.00	58.33	16.67	16.67
IC	36	36.00	58.33	22.22	5.56
Manager	34	34.00	41.18	17.65	11.76
VP	8	8.00	75.00	25.00	12.50

Additionally we found which position converts best through the job title, which turned out to be the CEO(33%) followed by Marketing managers(23%). We had to normalize these titles before hand and then we checked the funnel metrics for each title respectively. However we do see that the growth manager and VP sales had the highest reply rate. Since we don't have enough number of Growth manager leads data to conclude their ICP fit, we can say that for VP Sales this could be a sign that they find a lot of relatability in the copy but don’t align themselves with the product ICP as well.

Job_title	Leads	%_leads	reply_rate	qualify_rate	conversion_rate
Account Executive	28.00	28.00	67.86	25.00	7.14
CEO	6.00	6.00	66.67	33.33	33.33
Director of Sales	10.00	10.00	60.00	30.00	10.00
Founder	6.00	6.00	50.00	0.00	0.00
Growth Manager	4.00	4.00	75.00	0.00	0.00
Head of Growth	6.00	6.00	16.67	16.67	0.00
Marketing Manager	13.00	13.00	46.15	30.77	23.08
Revenue Operations	11.00	11.00	36.36	9.09	9.09

Manager					
Sales Development Representative	8.00	8.00	25.00	12.50	0.00
VP Sales	8.00	8.00	75.00	25.00	12.50

4.3 By Company Size — volume vs conversion across size bansds. We find that the leads that convert the most where belonging to companies of size in the range 51-200, converting at a 20% on all leads. This aligns with our existing ICP.

Company_size	Leads	%_leads	reply_rate	qualify_rate	conversion_rate
1-10	15.00	15.00	46.67	13.33	6.67
1000+	12.00	12.00	58.33	41.67	0.00
11-50	9.00	9.00	22.22	0.00	0.00
201-500	26.00	26.00	50.00	19.23	11.54
501-1000	13.00	13.00	92.31	15.38	7.69
51-200	25.00	25.00	52.00	28.00	20.00

4.4 By Funding Status — does recent funding signal buying intent

We found that most companies that converted didn't actually raise money at all, with all 3 qualified bootstrapped leads booked a meeting. This could imply that companies after raising prefer to use products from our higher end competitors or start working with agencies for DFY services, raising the question whether we should be monitoring other signals for buying intent, or create a product division focused on a new buying segment.

Funding_status	Leads	%_leads	reply_rate	qualify_rate	conversion_rate
Bootstrapped	13.00	13.00	53.85	23.08	23.08
Public	25.00	25.00	76.00	28.00	4.00
Seed	15.00	15.00	46.67	13.33	6.67
Series A	9.00	9.00	22.22	0.00	0.00
Series B	31.00	31.00	48.39	22.58	16.13
Series C	7.00	7.00	57.14	28.57	0.00

4.5 By Sales Rep/Team — performance differences across owners by using the waterfall rates at each stage of the funnel.

We found that all the reps, with the exception of Rep D showed similar conversion rates in the range of 42-57% with Rep C performing exceptionally well, while Rep D showed the least conversion rate at 33%.

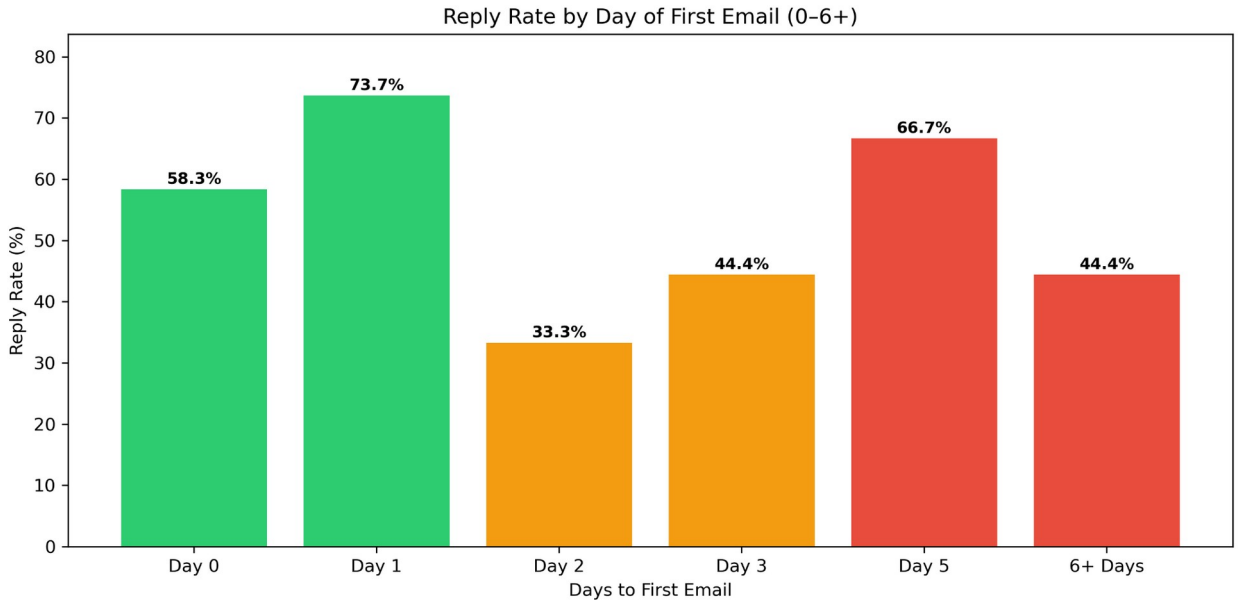
However, we can notice that the qualify rate varied by rep to rep even though they had been given from the same sample of randomly assigned leads. This is an indicator that the qualifying criteria had been too vague for the reps or showed a lack of competence in their ability to diagnose them as an ICP. This needs to be tackled as the high qualifying Reps converted at similar if not higher rates for each lead qualified that might have been missed by the other Reps.

Sales_owner	Leads	%_leads	reply_rate	qualify_rate	conversion_rate
Inbound_Team	19.00	19.00	42.11	25.00	50.00
Rep_A	21.00	21.00	61.90	53.85	42.86
Rep_B	15.00	15.00	60.00	22.22	50.00
Rep_C	24.00	24.00	58.33	50.00	57.14
Rep_D	21.00	21.00	47.62	30.00	33.33

*Note: The data uses waterfall rates, i.e. the denominator of the rate mentioned is the stage in Funnel immediately before it (for eg. the formula for qualify rate = qualified leads * 100 / leads that replied.) rather than the rates being a fraction of the total leads as a whole.*

5. Time-to-Respond Analysis

We found that leads were not contacted quickly: the median first email went out 3 days after form submission (mean 3.2), a quarter of leads waited about 5 days or more, and the longest wait was 7 days.



- **Distribution:** most first emails went out between Day 0 and Day 5, so a typical inbound lead waited about three days for a response to their own request.
- **Reply rate by timing:** emailing on Day 0 or Day 1 gives 58% and 74%, above the 54% overall rate, while Day 2 and Day 3 fall to 33% and 44%. Day 5 rebounds to 67%, but each bucket holds only a handful of leads, so this is more likely noise than a pattern.
- **Drop-off point:** the sharpest fall is between Day 1 and Day 2 (74% to 33%), and replies do not reliably recover after that. The chart covers reply rate only, not meeting rate by bucket.

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6. ICP Analysis

6.1 Current ICP

The Current ICP criteria for qualification was Company size in the range of 50-500, and funding stage at Series A, Series B, and Series C.

However, we found that the reply rates and qualify rates for the current ICP match were even lower than the non-ICP lead, even though the conversion rates were almost identical there seemed to be a drastic difference in the reply stage, which raises questions on both the quality of the outreach copy and the ICP criteria.

ICP_match	Leads	%_leads	reply_rate	qualify_rate	conversion_rate
FALSE	53.00	53.00	62.26	22.64	9.43
TRUE	47.00	47.00	44.68	19.15	10.64

*Note: The data uses waterfall rates, i.e. the denominator of the rate mentioned is the stage in Funnel immediately before it (for eg. the formula for qualify rate = qualified leads * 100 / leads that replied.) rather than the rates being a fraction of the total leads as a whole.*

6.2 Ideal ICP

Through further analysis we were able to identify a new segment of ICP or a better ICP criterion which supports the findings in **3.2** that show a drastic drop off in leads after the reply stage, we hypothesised that this could be either due to low number of leads that belonged to the ICP, or that the ICP Criteria needed revision.

After producing a new criteria to qualify, through using the highest converting leads for each criteria, we came to the conclusion the proposed ICP should be tested alongside the current ICP for an A/B testing to create a stronger ICP match.

CEO and Marketing managers, by extrapolation CMO.

51-200

Bootstrapped

6.3 Strongest predictors — The following signals were found to be the highest predictors of conversion in the data:

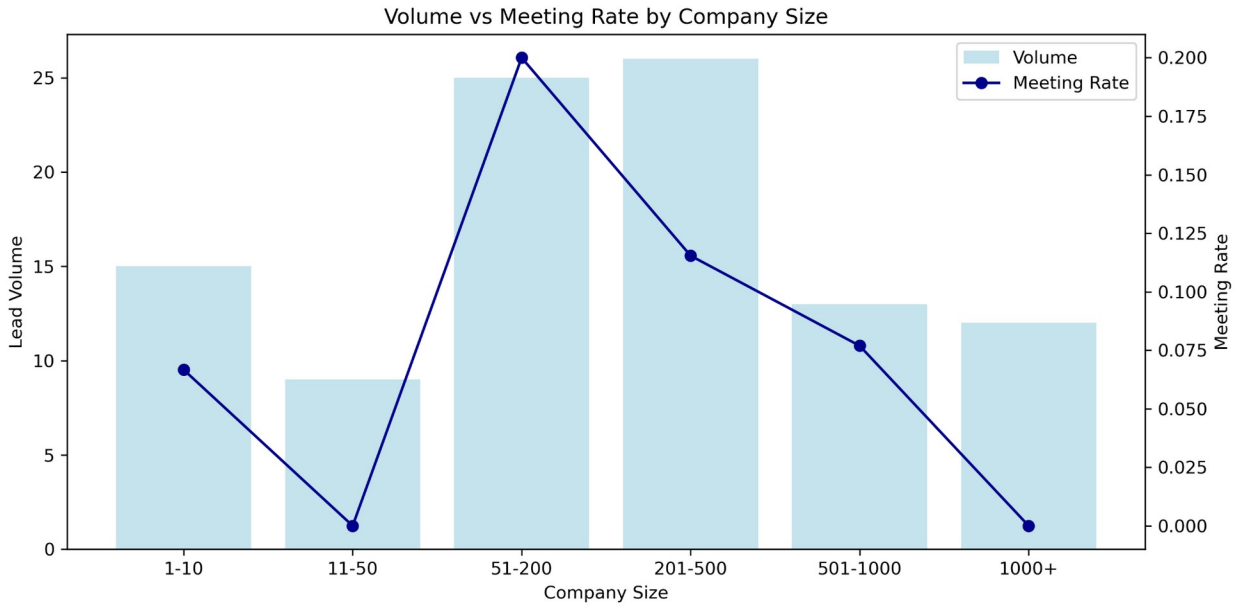
- **Company size 51-200:** 20% meeting rate, with 5 of the 10 meetings coming from 25% of leads.

- **Funding:** Bootstrapped converts at 23.1% (3 of 13) and Series B at 16.1% (5 of 31). Series A and Series C produced no meetings from 16 leads.
- **Job title:** CEO (33.3%, 2 of 6) and Marketing Manager (23.1%, 3 of 13) lead, though both samples are small.
- **Seniority within size band:** Managers at 51-200 (30%), Founders at 51-200 and 201-500 (25%, 33%), VPs at 201-500 (33%) and Managers at 501-1000 (33%). Each cell holds only a few leads, so these are leads to test rather than conclusions.

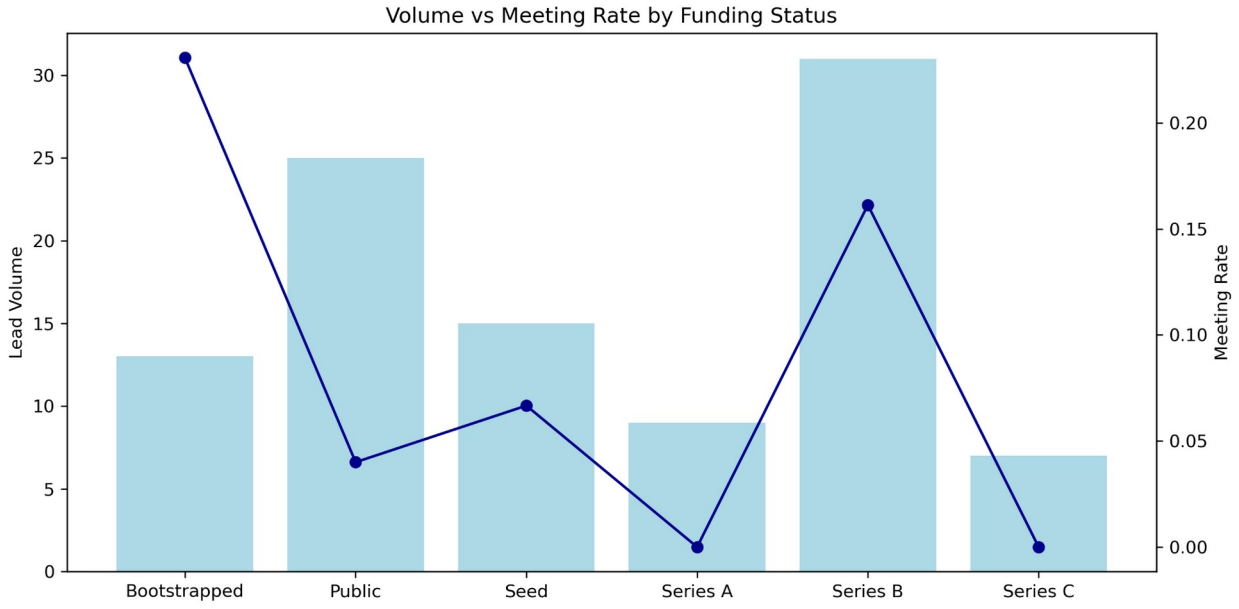
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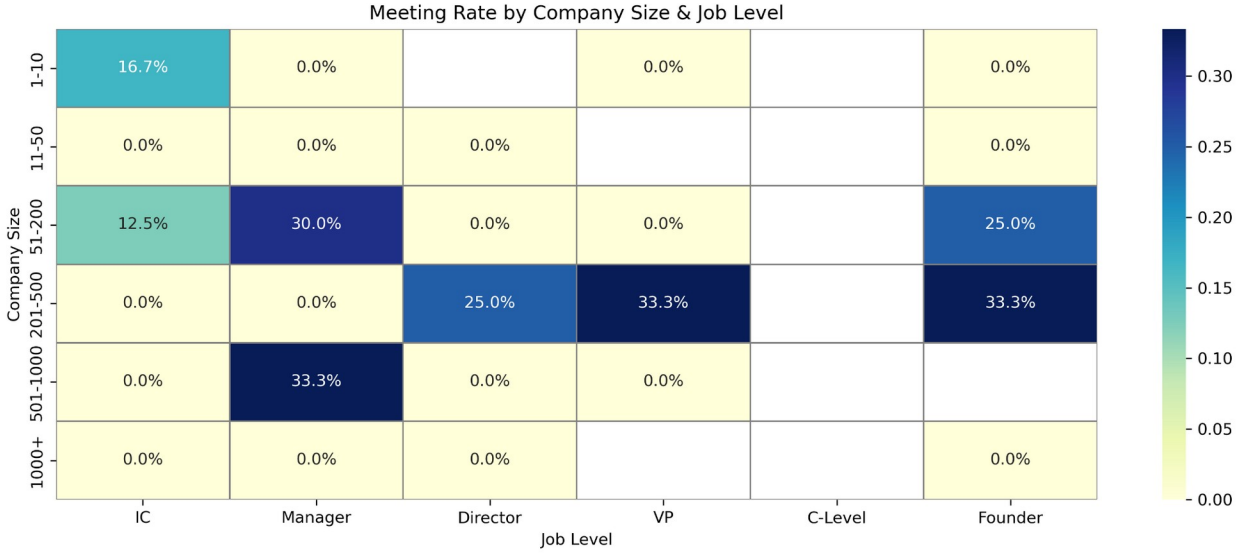
7. Prioritization Insights

- **High volume, low conversion (wasted effort):** ICs (36 leads, 5.6%), Account Executives (28 leads, 7.1%) and Public companies (25 leads, 4.0% despite a 76% reply rate). The Public result suggests replies that are not buying intent.
- **Low volume, high conversion (underprioritized):** CEOs (6 leads, 33%), Marketing Managers (13 leads, 23%) and Bootstrapped companies (13 leads, 23%). 51-200 is the one band that is both sizeable (25 leads) and high converting (20%).
- **Hold as is:** Series B (31 leads, 16.1%) and 201-500 (26 leads, 11.5%) are high volume and convert at or above the 10% average.



Volume peaks at 51-200 and 201-500, but only 51-200 converts well (20% vs 11.5%). The 11-50 and 1000+ bands produced no meetings from 21 leads.





Bootstrapped and Series B stand out on funding, while Public, Series A and Series C bring volume or replies without meetings. In the heatmap, meetings cluster at Manager level in 51-200 and at Founder and VP level in 201-500. Blank cells mean no leads, and most cells hold only a few.

8. Recommendations

8.1 Get the first email out within a day

Problem: First emails go out a median of 3 days after form submission.

Evidence: Reply rate is 58% and 74% when the email goes out on Day 0 or Day 1, against 33% and 44% on Day 2 and Day 3, and 54% overall (section 5).

Action: Trigger the first email automatically on form submission and alert the sales owner if nothing has gone out by the end of the next day.

Expected impact: Moving Day 2+ leads into the Day 0-1 window should lift the overall reply rate from 54% toward the 58-74% seen there. Buckets are small, so confirm with the experiment in section 9.

8.2 Test a revised ICP against the current one

Problem: The current ICP does not predict conversion.

Evidence: ICP-match leads replied less (44.7% vs 62.3%) and booked at the same rate (10.6% vs 9.4%). The best converting groups are 51-200 (20%), Bootstrapped (23.1%), CEOs (33.3%) and Marketing Managers (23.1%).

Action: A/B test the proposed ICP (CEO or Marketing Manager, 51-200, bootstrapped) against the current ICP for a fixed window, with meetings per lead as the measure. Keep Series B in the active pool, since it produced 5 of the 10 meetings.

Expected impact: If the proposed ICP holds near 20% against a 10% baseline, meetings per lead double. The segments are small, so the test should confirm this before the ICP is changed.

8.3 Standardize qualification across reps

Problem: Reply to qualify is the weakest stage (38%) and differs a lot by rep.

Evidence: On randomly assigned leads, qualify rate is 53.9% for Rep A, 50% for Rep C, 30% for Rep D, 25% for the Inbound Team and 22.2% for Rep B. Reps A and C also turned qualified leads into meetings at 42.9% and 57.1%.

Action: Write a qualification checklist tied to the ICP fields (job level, company size, funding) and review a sample of unqualified replies each week.

Expected impact: If Rep B, Rep D and the Inbound Team qualified at about 50%, the reply to qualify rate would rise from 38% to roughly 50%, assuming meeting conversion holds.

8.4 Move rep time away from low converting segments

Problem: Reps spend time on leads that rarely turn into meetings.

Evidence: ICs (36 leads, 5.6%), Public companies (25 leads, 4.0%), 11-50 and 1000+ bands (21 leads, 0 meetings) and Series A and C (16 leads, 0 meetings).

Action: Send these to an automated nurture sequence and escalate to a rep only on a second signal, such as a reply showing intent or a match on the revised ICP. Keep reps on 51-200, Series B and bootstrapped leads.

Expected impact: Frees rep capacity for the higher converting segments at little cost in meetings, since most of these groups produced 0-2 meetings each.

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9. Experiments & Further Data Collection

Reply within 1-2 days: send the first email within 1-2 days of submission for a test cohort and compare reply and meeting rates with the current 3 day median.

Test on growth managers: Growth Managers (4 leads) and VP Sales (8 leads) both replied at 75%, but none of the Growth Managers qualified. Send both groups tailored copy on a larger sample to see whether the interest converts.

Create new product for growth managers and vp sales: if the test shows steady interest without ICP fit, scope a separate offer for this group (starting with short conversations with the leads who replied) before building anything.

- Track UTM and form source more granularly, so lead quality can be compared by channel.
- A/B test subject lines by job level. VP Sales and Growth Managers reply at 75%, while Heads of Growth reply at 16.7%.
- Add reply sentiment tagging to separate interested replies from "not interested" ones. Public companies reply at 76% but book at 4%.
- Pull tech stack or intent data into the enrichment, so qualification does not rest only on title, size and funding.
